A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Jude 12–16

Portraits of Apostasy: What False Teachers Look Like

Small Group Bible Study Series · Jude

Source: The Gospel Vault
Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NASB · Jude 12–16

12 *These are the men who are hidden reefs in your love feasts when they feast with you without fear, caring for themselves; clouds without water, carried along by winds; autumn trees without fruit, doubly dead, uprooted;*

13 *wild waves of the sea, casting up their own shame like foam; wandering stars, for whom the black darkness has been reserved forever.*

14 *It was also about these men that Enoch, in the seventh generation from Adam, prophesied, saying, "Behold, the Lord came with many thousands of His holy ones,*

15 *to execute judgment upon all, and to convict all the ungodly of all their ungodly deeds which they have done in an ungodly way, and of all the harsh things which ungodly sinners have spoken against Him."*

16 *These are grumblers, finding fault, following after their own lusts; they speak arrogantly, flattering people for the sake of gaining an advantage.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *"…wild waves of the sea, casting up their own shame like foam; wandering stars, for whom the black darkness has been reserved forever."*

Jude's pictures come from the world everyone can see: the sea, the sky, the orchard, the harvest field. He does not need his readers to be scholars. He needs them to be observant. Fixed stars guide; wandering stars wreck ships. Fruit trees feed; uprooted ones decay. The test is not the presentation. It is what remains.

Enoch's prophecy adds something the pictures cannot: this judgment was announced before the flood. You are not sailing uncharted water. The chart has existed since the seventh generation from Adam.

And the portrait of verse 16 — grumblers, fault-finders, self-directed, arrogant and flattering at once — reminds us that the deepest diagnostic question is not only what a teacher says, but what is the settled attitude of his heart toward what God has given.

Reflect

1. Which of Jude's pictures best describes a pattern of teaching you have seen? What made it recognizable?
2. The word "grumblers" echoes Israel in the wilderness. What does chronic dissatisfaction with God's provision reveal?
3. What does it do for your trust in Scripture that this pattern was announced so far in advance?

The test is not the presentation. It is what remains when the cloud has passed.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Jude teaches his readers to recognize false teachers by what they fail to produce — and by the settled dispositions of their hearts — and reminds them that the verdict on this pattern was announced from the beginning.

Introduction — The Art of Recognition

Jude has told us what the intruders do (vv. 3–4) and the history their end follows (vv. 5–11). Now he shows us what they look like. Verses 12–16 are a gallery of portraits, drawn not with doctrinal propositions but with pictures from the natural world and with the oldest prophecy he can reach for. This section is meant to produce recognition, not just understanding.

That distinction matters pastorally. Understanding a threat is an intellectual exercise. Recognizing one is a matter of perception. Jude wants his readers to look at someone in their community and see, from the pattern of what is produced, whether the portraits fit. And he chooses pictures that anyone can use. A waterless cloud is recognizable to anyone who has ever hoped for rain. You do not need a seminary degree to know what a tree without fruit at harvest means.

There is a lesson here for an age in which platform size and charisma stand in for spiritual authority. Jude's criteria are different. The question is not how large the platform is or how compelling the speaker. It is what this teaching produces. Does it refresh or disappoint? Does it bear fruit or stay fruitless? Does it steer toward the harbor or toward the reef?

I. Six Pictures of Fruitlessness – vv. 12–13

Jude paints in two verses, moving from the harbor to the sea, the sky, the orchard, and the stars. Each picture shows a different side of the same failure: these men promise what they cannot deliver, produce what no one needs, and steer people off course.

A. Hidden reefs at your love feasts – v. 12a

The first picture is the most intimate: "hidden reefs in your love feasts." The Greek *spilades* is best understood as submerged rocks — dangerous formations hidden below the waterline that tear open a ship from below. The love feast was the shared meal of the early church, the most intimate regular gathering of the community. These men "feast with you without fear," sitting at the table of love as if they belonged, "caring for themselves." The last phrase literally means "shepherding themselves," an echo of Ezekiel 34, where God condemns shepherds who feed themselves and not the flock.

The pastoral implication is uncomfortable. The most dangerous people in a community are not those whose error is obvious. They are the ones who belong, who participate, who pray the same prayers. You cannot see a reef until it tears the hull. And the church's greatest strength — its welcome — is the very thing a hidden reef exploits. The answer is not to withdraw welcome but to pair it with wisdom.

The New Testament gives us a window into what went wrong at some love feasts. In Corinth, Paul had to correct divisions and selfishness at the gathering: "one is hungry and

another is drunk" (1 Corinthians 11:17–22). Peter says the false teachers "revel in their deceptions as they carouse with you" (2 Peter 2:13). The table of love can be turned into a place of self-service. The sin is not eating; it is "caring for themselves" at the very place where the body is meant to care for one another.

B. Clouds without water, carried along by winds – v. 12b

In the ancient Near East, clouds on the horizon meant rain, and rain meant life. A cloud that arrived and delivered nothing was a cruel reversal of hope. Jude says these men are such clouds, "carried along by winds." They have no fixed position of their own. They drift with whatever wind is blowing in the culture. They arrive looking like nourishment, and when people reach for it there is nothing there. This is the sermon that generates emotion without substance, impressive in appearance and empty in effect.

Proverbs has a proverb for it: "Like clouds and wind without rain is a man who boasts of his gifts falsely" (Proverbs 25:14). The man who promises more than he gives, whose talk outruns his substance, is a cloud and a wind. And notice that the proverb condemns the boasting more than the lack — what makes a waterless cloud is the claim it makes.

C. Autumn trees without fruit, doubly dead, uprooted – v. 12c

Trees bear in season. A tree at harvest with nothing on its branches has failed at its one purpose. Jude intensifies it: "doubly dead, uprooted." The picture is of something that is not dormant, waiting for spring, but dead and pulled out by the roots. The last possibility of recovery is gone.

A word on how to read this. Some take "doubly dead" as proof that these men never had life — that they were never truly God's — and then reason backward from lack of fruit to lack of salvation.[1] The picture itself says only that they have no fruit and no future. Jude does not settle their standing, and we should not either. The fruit question is a test for *teachers* (Matthew 7:15–20), who should be judged by what they produce. It is not a test of who is saved.[2]

Jesus Himself taught this test. "You will know them by their fruits," He said of false prophets, and the good tree bears good fruit while the bad tree is thrown into the fire (Matthew 7:15–20). In Luke 13:6–9 He tells of a fig tree that bore no fruit for three years, and of the vinedresser's plea for one more year of care. The fruit question is not meant to be mean. It is meant to protect the flock, and it is applied patiently.

D. Wild waves casting up their own shame – v. 13a

In Jewish imagery the sea stands for chaos, the restless force that resists God's order. Isaiah 57:20 says the wicked are like the tossing sea that "cannot be quiet" and whose waters "toss up refuse and mud." Jude's men are those waves — in constant motion, wild and uncontrolled, and all their energy produces is foam. The only thing they send ashore is the residue of their own disorder.

Paul uses this picture of instability too. Believers are no longer to be "children, tossed here and there by waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine" (Ephesians 4:14). James says the one who doubts is like "the surf of the sea driven and tossed by the wind" (James

1:6). Instability in teaching is not a small thing. It is the sea's own mark on the teacher, and the people who sit under him end up tossed with him.

E. Wandering stars – v. 13b

The last picture is the most ominous. Fixed stars were the navigators' anchors, trusted because they were always where they were supposed to be. A wandering star — a meteor, an erratic body deviating from its course — was not merely useless for navigation but dangerous. You could set your course by it and end up on the rocks. For these wandering stars "the black darkness has been reserved forever." The word is *tetērētai*, "has been kept" — the same root as verses 1, 6, 21, and 24. The darkness has been held in trust for them. God keeps His people for glory and keeps the wandering stars for the dark. The word is the same; the destinations are opposite.

There is a good counterpart for the wandering star. Daniel says "those who have insight will shine brightly like the brightness of the expanse of heaven, and those who lead the many to righteousness, like the stars forever and ever" (Daniel 12:3). Some stars guide; some lead nowhere. God calls His people to be fixed lights, not drifting ones, and the teachers among them to lead others to righteousness and not to themselves.

II. The Prophecy of Enoch – vv. 14–15

Now Jude reaches for his oldest witness: Enoch, "in the seventh generation from Adam," who prophesied "about these men also." The quotation is from 1 Enoch 1:9, a Jewish writing widely known in the first century. That has led some to ask whether Jude is treating 1 Enoch as Scripture. He is not. Paul quoted pagan poets (Acts 17:28; Titus 1:12) without endorsing their works. Jude quotes Enoch's prophecy because what it says is true and applies to the case. The authority lies in the inspired use Jude makes of it, not in the source it comes from.

The content is the point: "Behold, the Lord came with many thousands of His holy ones, to execute judgment upon all." The verb is the aorist "came" — a prophet speaking of the future as already done. And the word "ungodly" appears four times in a single verse: the ungodly, their ungodly deeds, done in an ungodly way, spoken by ungodly sinners. It is a hammering repetition. Whatever else may be said about these men, this is what defines them. The coming judgment is specific, not a sweeping condemnation, but a conviction of particular acts and particular words.

There is also wonder in this. Enoch saw it coming before the flood. Every generation of false teachers between Enoch and Jude, and every one between Jude and us, has lived under a verdict announced before any of them was born. God's word is as consistent as the pattern of rebellion it describes.

Enoch is also remembered as a man who "walked with God" and who "was taken up so that he would not see death" (Genesis 5:24; Hebrews 11:5). The one Jude quotes as a prophet of judgment was first a man of fellowship. That is how true prophecy works: those who know God best are the ones who tell the truth about His judgment. The two belong together.

III. The Portrait Completed – v. 16

Verse 16 closes the gallery with a portrait of the heart. Where verses 12–13 show what the intruders look like from outside, verse 16 shows what drives them.

1. Grumblers and fault-finders

"Grumblers" (*goggystai*) echoes Israel's wilderness murmuring — the same word family the Greek Old Testament uses for the people's complaining against Moses (Exodus 16:7–9). Murmuring is not a harmless personality trait. It is a settled conviction that God's provision is inadequate. "Finding fault" (*mempsimoiroi*) is its partner: constitutionally unable to be content with what has been given. The false teacher who grumbles against the apostolic deposit is the spiritual heir of the generation that murmured against the manna — and we have already seen where they ended (v. 5).

2. Following after their own lusts

They are not governed by the Spirit's desires (Galatians 5:16) but by their own. Their direction is set by appetite, not by truth. This is the interior side of "dreaming" in verse 8.

3. Arrogant and flattering

"They speak arrogantly, flattering people for the sake of gaining an advantage." Here is the revealing contradiction. The same person who speaks contemptuously of spiritual authority speaks warmly to anyone who can benefit him. It is not a contradiction at all. Both behaviors serve the same master: self.

Conclusion

The gallery of verses 12–16 is a gift to the church, not because it is comfortable but because it is practical. Jude does not require advanced training. He requires observation. Is there water in this cloud? Does this tree bear in season? Is this star fixed or wandering? What is left in the community after this teacher passes through — nourishment, or foam?

And v. 16 adds a second layer. Not only what is produced, but what drives the producing. Is this person governed by appetite or by truth? Chronically dissatisfied with what God gave, or content in it? These are observable patterns. They take time to see, but Jude trusts his community to see them.

Lord, give us eyes to recognize, and hearts that bear fruit.

Sources and Notes

1. Reformed use of "doubly dead" and fruit as evidence of regeneration: John F. MacArthur, *The Gospel According to Jesus* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1988; rev. 2008) and *The Gospel According to the Apostles* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2000); also Thomas R. Schreiner and Ardel B. Caneday, *The Race Set Before Us* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2001).

2. Free Grace on fruit, teachers, and assurance: Zane C. Hodges, *Absolutely Free! A Biblical Reply to Lordship Salvation* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1989); Robert N. Wilkin, *Confident in Christ* (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 1999); Robert N. Wilkin, ed., *The Grace New Testament Commentary* (2010), on Jude.

3. 1 Enoch 1:9 and the question of citation: see Thomas L. Constable, *Expository Notes on Jude*, planobiblechapel.org/tcon/notes/; NET Bible translators' notes on Jude 14–15; compare Acts 17:28 and Titus 1:12 for Paul's use of non-biblical sources.

4. Word studies: Blue Letter Bible lexicon entries G4694 (*spilas*), G4165 (*poimainō*), G3507 (*nephelē*), G504 (*anydros*), G1364 (*dis*), G1610 (*ekrizoō*), G1890 (*epaphrizō*), G4107 (*planētēs*), G765 (*asebēs*), G1113 (*goggystēs*), G3202 (*mempsimoiros*), G5246 (*hyperogkos*); BDAG, 3rd ed.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.12	**σπιλάδες** hidden reefs	G4694 spilades N-Nom. Pl. Fem.	STR: a rock or reef (also "spot"). Significance: NASB takes the maritime sense — hidden rocks that wreck ships from below. Danger at the table of fellowship.
v.12	**ποιμαίνοντες** caring for, shepherding	G4165 poimainontes Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to tend as a shepherd. Significance: "shepherding themselves" — the selfish shepherds of Ezek. 34 who fed themselves, not the flock.
v.12	**νεφέλαι ἄνυδροι** clouds without water	G3507 / G504 nephelai anydroi N-Nom. Pl. Fem. / Adj.	Significance: the promise of rain with no rain. Impressive in appearance, empty in effect.
v.12	**δὶς ἀποθανόντα** doubly dead	G1364 / G599 dis apothanonta Aor. Act. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Neut.	STR: twice; to die. Significance: emphatic lifelessness — no fruit, no recovery. Jude does not use it to settle anyone's standing before God.
v.12	**ἐκριζωθέντα** uprooted	G1610 ekrizōthenta Aor. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Neut.	STR: to root up. Significance: removed from the ground. The last hope of regrowth is gone.
v.13	**ἐπαφρίζοντα** casting up like foam	G1890 epaphrizonta Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Neut.	STR: to foam out. Significance: all their energy produces is the froth of their own shame.
v.13	**πλανῆται** wandering	G4107 planētai N-Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: a wanderer. Source of English "planet." Significance: unreliable guides; those who follow them are wrecked.
v.13	**τετήρηται** has been kept	G5083 tetērētai Perf. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg.	STR: to guard, keep. Significance: the same root as vv. 1, 6, 21. God keeps for glory or reserves for darkness.
v.14	**ἦλθεν** came	G2064 ēlthen Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	STR: to come. Significance: a prophetic aorist — the coming is so certain it is spoken of as done.
v.15	**ἀσεβεῖς** ungodly	G765 asebeis Adj.-Acc. Pl. Masc.	STR: irreverent, impious. Significance: appears four times in the verse (with related forms): the defining mark of those under judgment — treating God as irrelevant.
v.16	**γογγυσταί** grumblers	G1113 goggystai N-Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: a murmurer. Significance: the cognate noun *goggysmos* is Israel's wilderness murmuring (Exod. 16). Links v. 16 to the wilderness generation of v. 5.
v.16	**μεμψίμοιροι**	G3202	STR: complaining of one's lot. Significance: chronic

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
	fault-finders	mempsimoiroi Adj.-Nom. Pl. Masc.	dissatisfaction with what God has given.
v.16	**ὑπέρογκα** arrogant things	G5246 hyperonka Adj.-Acc. Pl. Neut.	STR: puffed-up, immense. Significance: swollen talk without substance — the verbal form of the waterless cloud.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
Why does Jude use natural images instead of doctrinal labels to describe the intruders?	Because images are accessible to everyone. A waterless cloud needs no seminary training to recognize. The pictures judge by what is produced.
What does the picture of “hidden reefs” teach about where the danger lies?	The most dangerous people are not the obviously false but those who belong — they sit at the love feast without fear.
How does the word *tetērētai* (“has been kept”) in v. 13 connect to vv. 1 and 6?	The same root appears for believers kept for Christ and angels kept in bonds. God keeps for glory or reserves for darkness — the keeping is purposeful either way.
Why does Jude quote Enoch, and does this make 1 Enoch Scripture?	He quotes it because what it says is true and fits the case. Paul quoted non-biblical sources too (Acts 17:28). It does not make 1 Enoch canonical.
What does “doubly dead” tell us — and not tell us — about these men?	It tells us they bear no fruit and have no future. It does not settle their standing before God; the fruit question tests teachers (Matt. 7:15–20), not who is saved.
What do “grumblers,” “finding fault,” and “arrogantly… flattering” reveal about the intruders?	A settled dissatisfaction with what God has given, a self-directed life, and self-serving speech — arrogant to authority, flattering to anyone useful.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Which of the five pictures best fits a pattern of teaching you have seen? What made it recognizable?

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.A–E.*

2. How can a welcoming church stay discerning without becoming suspicious?

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.A — hidden reefs and the table.*

3. What does it mean that “the black darkness has been kept” (v. 13) in the same word God uses for keeping believers?

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.E — tēreō thread.*

4. What is the difference between testing a teacher by his fruit and testing a person's salvation by their fruit?

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.C — Matthew 7:15–20; Free Grace and Reformed readings.*

5. Which of the portraits in v. 16 is hardest for you to see in yourself? What could you do about it?

> *Leader note: See Commentary III.*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
v. 12a	Hidden reefs	Danger hides at the table of fellowship; self-serving shepherds.
v. 12b	Clouds without water	Promise without substance; no anchor.
v. 12c	Autumn trees, doubly dead, uprooted	No fruit, no future — a test for teachers, not salvation.
v. 13	Wild waves; wandering stars	Disorder produces only shame; false guides end in kept darkness.
vv. 14–15	Enoch's prophecy	The verdict on the ungodly was announced from the beginning.
v. 16	The portrait of the heart	Grumbling, fault-finding, lust-led, arrogant, and flattering — all in service of self.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Use Jude's Tests

Jude 12–13

Drawn from Commentary I. Key terms: spilades (hidden reefs), planētai (wandering).

Jude shifts the community's attention from inputs — credentials, platforms, following — to outputs. A cloud is judged by rain. A star is judged by whether it is fixed. A tree is judged at harvest. Use these as cumulative patterns, not single-sermon verdicts.

Reflection: Think of a teacher or teaching you regularly consume. Which of Jude's pictures, if any, comes to mind?

Practical Step: For one month, keep a short log of what remains after what you read, hear, or watch: nourishment, direction, fruit — or foam.

Application 2 — Know the Ancient Pattern

Jude 14–15

Drawn from Commentary II. Key term: asebeis (ungodly).

The pattern of false teaching is not new, and neither is God's verdict on it. Enoch announced it before the flood. That is stabilizing: the church is not facing something unprecedented.

Reflection: As a group: which part of Jude's portrait do you see most in the church today?

Practical Step: Compare Jude 14–15 with 1 Enoch 1:9 (in a study Bible or online). What does Jude keep, and what does he leave?

Application 3 — Test the Disposition, Not Only the Doctrine

Jude 16

Drawn from Commentary III. Key terms: goggystai (grumblers), mempsimoiroi (fault-finders).

Doctrinal error can be subtle. Dispositions often show sooner: chronic complaint about what God has given, a life led by appetite, arrogance toward authority and flattery toward influence. Jude is describing settled patterns, not bad days.

Reflection: Is there an area where you are acting like a grumbler — treating God's provision as inadequate?

Practical Step: List three things God has given you in the faith, the church, or your life that you have treated as insufficient. Receive them this week with thanks.

Application 4 — The Fruit Question

Jude 12; Matthew 7:15–20

Drawn from Commentary I.C. FGR: Hodges, Absolutely Free!; RTR: MacArthur, The Gospel According to Jesus.

A tree is judged at harvest. The same is true of teaching: what does it leave in people's lives? We keep this question for teachers and teachings. We do not turn it into a test of someone's salvation — Jude does not.

Reflection: How would you answer the fruit question about the teaching that has shaped you most over the last five years?

Practical Step: Read Matthew 7:15–20 with Jude 12. Write one sentence on what they teach together about evaluating teachers.

End of Study · Jude 12–16